

SPEAKER'S NOTES: "The Scroll That Never Ends"

Your prep kit for the segment — speakable lines are in quotes.

1. COLD OPEN (first 30 seconds)

"Every one of us has had that moment — you look up, and somehow it's been 40 minutes, and you can't name a single thing you just saw. That feeling is not a personal failure. It is an engineering achievement — and the engineer is on record apologizing for it."

That's your hook. Don't explain infinite scroll yet. Make them feel it first.

2. THE STORY (the part everyone underestimates)

The beat-by-beat version to tell:

2006. A brilliant interface designer named **Aza Raskin** has a genuinely good idea: clicking "next page" is wasted effort. Why not just let content load as you scroll? Pure, elegant friction removal. Nobody thought it was sinister — least of all him.

The catch nobody asked about: What was that little click actually *doing* for us? It was a speed bump. It gave your brain one second to ask a question: "*Do I want to keep going?*"

"Infinite scroll doesn't just remove the click. It removes the *question*."

The irony: Aza's father, Jef Raskin, started the Macintosh project — the computer designed to be friendly to humans. The son made humans friendly to the app. And today Aza is one of tech's loudest dissenters — you may recognize him from *The Social*

Dilemma; he co-founded the Center for Humane Technology to fight exactly what he built.

The history wrinkle (this makes you look sharp, not scripted): the "one lone inventor" story is too tidy. Patents and prototypes for similar scrolling mechanics were floating around the same year — including from a Microsoft search team. Invention is rarely a lightning strike. It's weather.

3. THE NUMBERS THAT LAND

Don't drown them in stats. Pick two:

- **Raskin's own estimate** — by his back-of-the-envelope math, infinite scroll devours the equivalent of hundreds of thousands of human lifetimes of human attention, every month. Hedge it on air: "*by his own estimate.*"
- **Do the audience's math instead:** "Call it two and a half hours a day on feeds. That's a full month of your year — every year. Roughly **five years of an adult life**, spent thumbing glass."

Your killer contrast line:

"Netflix — a company whose entire business is keeping you on the couch — built in a stopping cue: 'Are you still watching?' Your social feed has *never once asked*. Even the binge factory gives you an exit ramp."

Add one context point if the host bites: old media was finite by *physics*. The newspaper ran out. The show ended. The book had a back cover. Those endings were doing us a favor. Your brain has no native sensor for "enough" — and the feed knows it.

4. THE SPICY DEBATE (your three angles, with ammo for both sides)

Angle 1: Should it be banned on kids' apps?

- *Yes, and it's already happening:* "This isn't hypothetical. New York, California, Minnesota — lawmakers have literally written the words 'infinite scroll' and 'autoplay'

into bills about 'addictive feeds.' The UK and EU already treat manipulative design aimed at minors as a regulatory category."

- Sound bite: *"We don't let casinos issue slot machines to 13-year-olds. A personalized, never-ending feed is a slot machine that knows you better than your mother does."*
- **No — the smart counter:** "You can ban the scroll, but you can't ban the business model. Kill the feed and you'll get 500 taps on 'click for next,' because holding attention still pays the bills. **Regulate the outcome — time limits, mandatory stopping cues, no engagement-ranked feeds for minors — not the widget.**"
- **Your proof platforms can do it:** "Instagram added 'You're all caught up.' TikTok set 60-minute defaults for teens. They know how. They do it when lawmakers glare hard enough."

Angle 2: Is the scroll the villain, or just a symptom?

"Infinite scroll is the syringe, not the drug. The drug is the ad model — every extra minute of attention is revenue, so every design gets A/B tested against one question: *does it keep them here longer?* In that world, a stopping cue never survives."

Bonus flex: it's never one feature. It's scroll + autoplay + notifications + streaks + likes — even pull-to-refresh, the little tug at the top of your feed, was built to feel like a slot machine lever, and *its* inventor has publicly wrestled with that too. This is an ecosystem.

Angle 3: Does removing friction always backfire?

"No — and that's the trap. One-click checkout, streaming, autocorrect: brilliant, all of them. Here's the test: **does the feature help you finish something, or keep you from ever finishing?** Shopping has a cart. A book has a last page. A feed has neither. Removing friction toward a destination is convenience. Removing friction where there's no destination is compulsion."

And the scholarly anchor that makes you the expert: a Nobel laureate named **Herbert Simon** called this in 1971 — *"a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention."* We built the wealth. He warned us about the poverty.

5. ANALOGY BANK (grab one, don't stack all)

- **The casino:** "A casino removes clocks, windows, and cash. A feed removes pages, endings, and clocks. Same playbook, different chips."
 - **The bottomless soup bowl:** psychologists famously ran a study with bowls secretly refilled through a tube under the table — people ate 73% more and didn't know it, some insisting they couldn't be full because the bowl wasn't empty. *"Your feed is a bottomless bowl, and the only gauge you've got is a battery icon."* (Small honesty flag: this study's author was later heavily scrutinized — deploy it as an illustration, not gospel.)
 - **The buffet:** "Blaming infinite scroll for the attention crisis is like blaming the all-you-can-eat buffet for obesity. It's not the plate — it's what's being served and who profits."
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6. CURVEBALLS THE HOST MIGHT THROW

"People wasted time before phones. TV, novels, comics?"

"Sure — but the broadcast day *ended*. Finite media fired a starting gun and a finish line. This is the first entertainment in history with no back cover, no final episode — and it's custom-built for you, and it follows you to bed. Different sport."

"Isn't this just personal responsibility?"

"You're not debating your own willpower. You're playing against teams of engineers running thousands of experiments on billions of people. Bring willpower — but let's not pretend it's a fair fight."

"The internet is free because of ads."

"It's not free. It's just not priced in dollars — we pay in minutes. Fine. But then the least we can demand is a receipt."

7. THE CALL-IN MOMENT

Their framing is good — sharpen it:

"Have you ever looked up from your phone and had no idea how much time had passed? Call in — and better yet: what trick have you tried to escape the scroll, and did it survive a week?"

For parents specifically: "Do your kids' screen-time reports scare you? What have you actually tried?"

When you take calls: validate first ("you're not alone — that's the design working"), then convert their story into one of your concepts (stopping cues, variable rewards).

8. GIVE THE AUDIENCE SOMETHING TO DO TONIGHT

"Re-add the friction the designers removed. Log out every time. Take the app off your home screen so you have to search. Kill autoplay first — biggest single win. Turn on grayscale; the feed is a lot less delicious in black and white. And before you unlock the phone, say out loud *why* you're picking it up. It sounds silly. It works — because it puts back the one thing infinite scroll deleted: a decision."

9. YOUR CLOSING LINE (the mic-drop)

"Aza Raskin built a world with no off-ramps, and he's spent years begging us to build the exits back. But here's the part no designer can do for you: **the scroll never ends on its own. It only ends when you do.**"

QUICK FACT-CHECK BEFORE YOU GO ON AIR

These protect you from getting corrected live:

1. **The lifetimes figure:** Raskin's most widely quoted version is ~200,000 lifetimes *per day* (BBC, 2018). Your brief says half a million *per month* — different orders of magnitude. Pick one, and always attribute: "*by his own estimate.*"

2. **The 2026 Meta trial / testimony:** confirm status and date before asserting it as fact — otherwise soften to "ongoing litigation against major platforms."
 3. **The Microsoft patent:** frame it as "the history is contested," not a hard claim.
 4. **State laws (NY, CA, etc.):** signed in 2024, implementation still rolling out — say "now coming into force," not "already in force."
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Delivery rule for the whole segment: analogy *before* statistic. Land the feeling, then the number. And keep answers to 25 seconds — you're building a highlight reel, not a lecture.